an opponent and always assist him to save his face. Put yourself in his shoes—so as to see things through his eyes. Avoid self-righteousness like the devil—nothing is so self-blinding."[3]

Throughout the American deliberations Kennedy called on his advisers—the so-called Ex Comm—to put themselves in Khrushchev's shoes: "I think we ought to think why the Russians did this." When advisers urged a surprise air strike on the bases, Kennedy commented that our allies would regard it "as a mad act by the United States." He did not think Khrushchev would initiate a nuclear war he was bound to lose. He sought to make it as easy as possible for him to back down.

But the President worried insistently that the situation might meanwhile spin out of control through miscalculation, accident, stupidity, insanity, something going terribly wrong down the line (cf. General Ripper in *Dr. Strangelove*). He had not read in vain *The Guns of August*, Barbara Tuchman's account of the way the nations of Europe stumbled into the First World War. Thus he took the greatest care to keep the armed forces on the tightest leash, much to their ill-concealed irritation.

Kennedy was not impressed by military objections. The Bay of Pigs had taught the President to distrust the Joint Chiefs of Staff. "The first advice I'm going to give my successor," he once said to his journalist friend Ben Bradlee, "is to watch the generals and to avoid feeling that because they were military men their opinions on military matters were worth a damn."[4] During the missile crisis Kennedy courteously and consistently rejected the Joint Chiefs' bellicose recommendations. "These brass hats have one great advantage in their favor," he said. "If we…do what they want us to do, none of us will be alive later to tell them that they were wrong."[5]

He did not know that Soviet tactical nukes were lying in wait for an American invasion. But he feared the awful unpredictability of escalation. Once the escalatory spiral took off, who knows where it would end? That is why the President resisted a sneak air attack, even when a majority of the Ex Comm favored it. That is why he prepared to enlist the United Nations in fallback plans in case bilateral negotiation faltered. That is why from an early point he saw a trade of American missiles in Turkey for Soviet missiles in Cuba as a possible way out.

And that is why he sent Robert Kennedy on a secret mission to Ambassador Anatoly Dobrynin to arrange the trade. It was a deal most of his advisers opposed. This is an episode only lightly touched on in *Thirteen Days*. Secrecy was deemed essential lest disclosure of the trade